

Willard Robinson

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, North Carolina State University, Raleigh, NC	2022 – 2027 (expected)
Committee: Profs. Spencer Banzhaf (Advisor), Erin Sills, Roger von Haefen, & Zhenxuan Wang	
M.S. in Applied Economics, Montana State University, Bozeman, MT	2020 – 2022
B.A. in Economics (<i>summa cum laude</i>), Appalachian State University, Boone, NC	2018 – 2020
Minor: Mathematics	

RESEARCH FIELDS

Environmental and natural resource economics, Environmental markets, Nonmarket valuation

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Asymmetric Information and Transaction Costs in Voluntary Conservation Markets” [PDF]

- Abstract:** Emissions trading systems now cover roughly 30% of global greenhouse gas emissions, and offsets promise substantial gains from trade between capped sectors and cheaper abatement elsewhere. I extend van Benthem and Kerr’s (2013) model of nature-based offset supply: landowners hold private information about the commercial value of their land and respond to a uniform baseline-price mechanism, but must also pay a privately known fixed cost to participate. The private information and the costly participation—acting alone—reduce the social value of such a market, but are not socially harmful. Together, however, they can be. I show that an offset market can be strictly welfare-reducing, so that closing it dominates every active policy. The two frictions play distinct roles: private information about the commercial value governs who is drawn into the market, costly participation determines how much welfare they create. Because willingness to participate is highest for those landowners with the least commercially-valuable land, the landowners who are the hardest to exclude from a market are precisely those who generate the lowest social value. Two further results follow. The optimal baseline plays a screening role absent from current protocols; and the optimal price may lie strictly below the Pigouvian benchmark, separating welfare-positive from welfare-negative landowners by exploiting differences in their willingness to participate at differing levels of policy stringency. Improving baseline accuracy, the focus of recent policy debate, is therefore necessary but not sufficient to make these markets work.

WORKING PAPERS

“Adoption Costs for Offsets: Evidence from California,” Under Review [PDF]

- First place, William D. Toussaint Best Paper Award, NC State Economics Department

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Recreation Welfare Effects with Climate Change-Induced Migration”

“Impacts of Centralized Budget Policy on National Parks: An Analysis of the Federal Land Recreation Enhancement Act”

“The Value of Shoreline Recreational Fishing Across Time and Space: An Internal Meta-Regression Approach,” with Sasha Naumenko, Colton Leach, & Roger von Haefen

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

CEnREP Graduate Research Assistant for Prof. Spencer Banzhaf, NC State University	Jan. 2024 – Present
“Making Markets Work” “The Market for Environmental Offsets”	
Graduate Research Assistant for Prof. Umut Dur, NC State University	Jan. 2025 – Jan. 2026
“Stability in Centralized College Major Assignment: Evidence from NCSU Engineering”	

Graduate Research Assistant for Prof. Nick Hagerty, Montana State University	Aug. 2020 – May 2022
• “<i>Anticipatory Effects of Regulating the Commons</i>” with Ellen Bruno (2025), Journal of Environmental Economics and Management, vol. 132: 103183	
Research Assistant for Prof. John Whitehead, Appalachian State University	Jun. 2019 – May 2020
• Non-market valuation	
Research Assistant for Prof. Brock Stoddard, Appalachian State University	Jun. 2019 – May 2020
• Experimental economics	

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Independent Instructor, NC State University	Fall 2025
• ARE 336: Introduction to Environmental and Resource Economics (Undergraduate): Fall 2025	
Independent Instructor, Montana State University	2021 – 2022
• ECNS 202: Principles of Macroeconomics (Undergraduate): Fall 2021, Spring 2022	
Graduate Teaching Assistant, NC State University	2022 – 2025
• ARE 336: Introduction to Environmental and Resource Economics (Undergraduate): Fall 2023, Spring 2025 • ECG 702: Microeconomic Theory II (Ph.D.): Spring 2024 • EC 201: Principles of Microeconomics (Undergraduate): Fall 2022, Spring 2022, Fall 2023 (Head TA)	
Graduate Teaching Assistant, Montana State University	2020 – 2022
• ECNS 202: Principles of Macroeconomics (Undergraduate): Summer 2021, Summer 2022 • ECNS 403R: Introductory Econometrics (Undergraduate): Fall 2020	

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS AND GRANTS

Andrew J. & Thelma K. Bartley Endowed Graduate Fellowship, Poole College of Management	2026
NBER Travel Grant	2026
Best Fourth Year Paper Award, Department of Economics, NC State University	2026
PERC Graduate Summer Fellowship, Property and Environment Research Center	2025
Top Student in Economics, Appalachian State University	2020

SEMINARS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS (INCLUDING SCHEDULED*)

“Asymmetric Information and Transaction Costs in Voluntary Conservation Markets”	
• Camp Resources XXXII (2026), AERE @ the Southern Economic Association (2026*), Triangle Theory Workshop (2026*), Appalachian State University (2026*), East Carolina University (2026*)	
“Adoption Costs for Offsets: Evidence from California”	
• NCSU Economics Third Year Workshop (2025), North Carolina State University (2026)	
“Impacts of Centralized Budget Policy on National Parks: An Analysis of the Federal Land Recreation Enhancement Act”	
• Property and Environment Research Center (2025), Appalachian Experimental and Environmental Workshop (2024)	
“Recreation Welfare Effects with Climate Change-Induced Migration”	
• NCSU Graduate Student Seminar Series (2025)	

SERVICE

Referee: AERE @ the Southern Economic Association conference, *Environmental Research Letters*

Graduate Student Seminar Organizer, NC State University

2025 – Present

Vice President, Economics Graduate Student Association, NC State University

2024 – Present

OTHER INFORMATION

Programming: Julia, Git, $\text{\LaTeX}$, MATLAB, R, SAS, Stata

Memberships: American Economic Association, Association of Environmental and Resource Economists, European Association of Environmental and Resource Economists

REFERENCES

Prof. Spencer Banzhaf (Advisor)
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Prof. Roger von Haefen
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